

Policy paths: what markets price against the central banks' own rules

Weekly brief, 28 September 2026 · USD as of 21 Sep · GBP as of 25 Sep · generated 2026-09-29

For each currency, the market-implied path of the policy rate over the next eight meetings, against the path a balanced-approach rule would take on the macro data public that day, held flat. The gap is market minus rule; its z is against the gap's own trailing two years.



The gaps, by meetings ahead (the charts label gap 4 and gap 8)

	as of	gap 1	gap 4	gap 8	z 1	z 4	z 8
USD	21 Sep	-1bp	+5bp	-16bp	+1.0	+2.2	+2.1
GBP	25 Sep	+42bp	+136bp	+225bp	+2.2	+1.8	+1.8
GBP – USD	21 Sep	+42bp	+135bp	+238bp	+1.3	+1.1	+1.3

GBP – USD is gap minus gap on the sessions both have: +135bp at the fourth meeting (z +1.1), its level mostly the two r* choices.

The trades, before costs: what holding each signal earns or costs (CR), and a round trip (RT)

	as of	z	side	instrument	edge	CR 91d	E 91d	RT	carry and roll
USD outright	21 Sep	+2.2	receive	ZQ Apr 2027	+50bp	+26bp	+36bp	1.05bp	earns carry and roll
GBP outright	25 Sep	+1.8	receive	OIS forward 18 Mar-29 Apr 2027	+83bp	+32bp	+39bp	1.00bp	earns carry and roll
USD 2s10s	21 Sep	+0.4*	receive	2y vs 10y Treasury	+6bp	+15bp	+14bp	1.00bp	earns carry and roll
GBP 2s10s	25 Sep	+0.0*	receive	2y vs 10y gilt	+0bp	+10bp	+3bp	2.00bp	earns carry and roll
GBP - USD 2y	21 Sep	+1.1	receive	2y gilt vs 2y Treasury	+38bp	-4bp	+4bp	1.50bp	bleeds, pays

Edge: de-measured gap (curve, cross: a proxy for the legs' move). CR: carry and roll, curve frozen. E: past closure of the edge, CR on the rest. * |z| < 1.

What changed since last week

USD: no session since 21 Sep, so nothing to compare yet.

GBP (21 Sep to 25 Sep): the gap at the fourth meeting moved -3bp to +136bp (z +1.9 to +1.8): the market -3bp, the rule +0bp.

What would make this wrong

The widest reading is USD at the fourth meeting (z +2.2, +5bp: the market prices more tightening than the rule). It is wrong if the market is right that Core PCE (3.4%) and unemployment will not stay where they are: the rule holds them flat, so a market pricing their change looks mispriced to it when it is not.

Limitations (from the data-quality and lag tags in config)

USD: scheduled FOMC dates are treated as known on every date (fomc.csv records no publication date) · USD: core PCE's latest one or two months are bridged from core CPI until PCE prints (real-time RMSE 0.075pp m/m) · USD: CBO's natural rate has vintages only from 2011-02-02, so the model path starts 2011-03-04 · USD/GBP: hold-flat conditioning: inflation, the unemployment gap and r* stay at today's values at every meeting · USD/GBP: the rule is imposed from the Fed's Monetary Policy Report, not estimated · USD: r* is the SEP median as FRED rounds it (to within 5bp); Taylor's 2% before the first dot, 2012-01-25 · USD: Treasury legs are H.15 constant-maturity par yields: a fitted curve, not traded bonds · USD: 34 of 3,921 USD sessions have no Treasury yields (bond market shut, CME open): a leg carries its last print · USD/GBP: a par leg is funded at the overnight rate, standing in for repo · USD/GBP: legs are DV01-linear, so the P&L leaves out convexity: under 3bp a year per unit DV01 on a 2s10s receive, 7bp at most (2022) · GBP: the Bank's OIS curve has monthly maturities, so a meeting's step is placed by interpolating between them; against the Bank's own MPR conditioning paths the path is within 1.0bp on average · GBP: scheduled MPC dates are treated as known on every date; the September 2022 meeting is listed on the 22nd, where it was moved to · GBP: CPI release days before February 2016 are dated the 26th of the month (up to ~10 days late, never early) · GBP: LFS release days before April 2016 are dated the 26th of the month (up to ~10 days late, never early) · GBP: LFS unemployment is noisy after the 2023 response-rate collapse: suspended Oct 2023-Jan 2024 (the last official vintage is held), "official statistics in development" Feb 2024-Aug 2026, volatile in mid-2023 and 2024, and a collection error in May-June 2026 degraded releases from July · GBP: u* is a constant 4.5%, not a real-time estimate · GBP: r* is a constant (-1.6%, the 2009-26 average real Bank Rate): a hindsight number that moves the bp gap, not the z · GBP: the outright is a meeting-dated OIS forward on the Bank's fitted curve, not a traded contract · GBP: gilt legs are par yields from the Bank's fitted spot curve, not traded gilts; a missing 0.5y point is interpolated (at most 0.3bp on 2y par) · GBP: GBP legs convert at the H.10 noon New York rate, not the London close, carried over Fed holidays (132 of 4,063 GBP sessions)